

Karis Fellowships in Romans: Summary of Ch. 1

The letter to the Romans begins with a description of who we are and our mission as human creatures connected to our Creator. Paul first describes the unique person of Jesus whose heritage is human and yet was shown to be divine by His resurrection. He is our example as humans who are descended in the flesh, or the material, and yet become the children of God.

(vss. 1-7) Paul first presents Jesus as this representative of material and divine, fully connected to the Creator. Then he presents himself as the next example, not as Lord, but as servant of that Lord and responding to Him in karis relationship. He was invited (called) into that relationship and given work to do. Paul responds with the gift of his work or mission serving the One who called.

(vss. 8-17) Next Paul details what that relationship looks like for human creatures. His first response is gratitude. This is especially important to note because he will show us that one of the characteristics of disconnection from our Creator is ingratitude. Through his own example of gratitude for the efforts others are making, his prayer for them, and his desire to be in their presence, he shows us how connected people respect and enjoy other connected people. Perhaps the most astonishing of Paul's desire is not only to give his gifts, but he also hopes to receive gifts that will encourage him. I rarely meet a Christian leader who looks forward to receiving encouragement from other believers, especially from those that they lead. Paul acknowledges their faith to be as equally productive as his own. Paul recognizes and affirms that they are making valuable choices that reveal their trust in God, just as he is.

By connecting with them, and all of them connecting with God, fruit is produced. We will see this idea of fruit coming up again. Fruit can only be produced through the joining of two different genders, two creatures that are distinctly different yet very much alike. It is the combined effort of two creatures, different yet alike, that produces fruit. Fruit cannot be produced from two of the same creatures, or beings.

Paul believes himself to be in karis debt to other nations and peoples who are also human creatures. Other streams of thought and belief have influenced his culture and training, and he is grateful. Bringing the gospel to the Greeks and to other nations in the Mediterranean is a marvelous gift in return for all that they have done for him. He invites karis with believers, or the trusting ones, but he also invites karis with non-believers, those who are not yet in a trusting relationship with God. His audience may not appreciate Paul's interest in helping those outside of the privileged world of Rome. Greeks and barbarians were not considered to be proper citizens and Romans tended to despise the peoples that they had conquered.

(vss. 18-32) This part of Paul's teaching is more in line with what these Romans want to hear. Paul begins to blast those despicable people. I can just feel the Romans' contempt mounting as Paul supports their judgments against these people. He points out their many crimes against God. As creatures themselves, they have attached to other created things!

Paul especially plays up the disgusting worship practices of the ancient Egyptians and Greeks. Creatures worshipping creatures is just as unproductive as males sexually engaging with males, or females with other females. Passion that should be directed in worship toward God is shunted into trying to connect with created things. The list of despicable qualities toward the end of the chapter is in the Greek language much more stylized for oratory. We might listen to some of our African-American preachers who can achieve the same effect by using common syllables, vowel sounds, prefixes, and shades of meaning in their rhythmic style to get the point across to people who are listeners and not readers. At this point in the letter, Paul has the Romans thoroughly worked up against those disgusting non-Romans. He doesn't leave them for long in that condition of contemptuous judgment, however. He sails right into accusing them of what their judgments say about them.